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FUNDAMENTAL FLAW

Expansion, excellence and inclusion. Adequate emphasis on quality education and vocational training. Only these can help us compete in the global knowledge economy.

Today it is widely recognised that the 21st Century will be driven by knowledge, and a nation's competitive advantage in the global economy will be sustained by a focused and innovative education agenda. To meet the challenges of this century, India needs to usher in a knowledge revolution that seeks to bring about systemic changes in the education and knowledge structures of the country.

Reform in the education system is critical for meeting the challenges posed by demography, disparity and development, and for creating an empowered generation for the future. While our economy has made significant strides, the education system has not kept pace with the aspirations of the 550 million below the age of 25, a demographic that has the potential to constitute one-fourth of the global workforce by 2020. Consequently, we have not been able to harness our greatest asset—our human resource. To leverage this asset, a focused education and skill development agenda is needed that provides innovative solutions to our current challenges. The vast disparity in the country today is a result of skewed access to knowledge. To address this, we need a substantial expansion in educational opportunities, with a special emphasis on inclusion so that nobody is left out of the system. Finally, to accelerate the course of sustainable development in the country, efforts have to be undertaken to create an educational system that nourishes innovation, entrepreneurship and addresses the skill requirements of a growing economy.

To initiate this process of reform, the government needs a focused agenda to address the concerns of the school, vocational and higher education streams.

We need to bring about a paradigm shift in our education systems with the perspective of enhancing access and employability, and generating long-term qualitative changes that enable us to compete in the global knowledge economy.

At the bottom of the knowledge pyramid, steps must be taken to enhance access to quality elementary education, given the low levels of enrolment and high percentage of dropouts at the school level. This requires a Central legislation affirming the Right to Education. Making access to good school education a reality also requires major expansion at the secondary and elementary levels and generational changes in the school system with emphasis on local autonomy in management of schools, decentralisation and flexibility in disbursement of funds.

Further, the curriculum and examination systems should be overhauled to encourage conceptual understanding of subjects and a move away from an assessment system that rewards rote learning. With English being seen as an important determinant of access to higher education and employment possibilities, English language teaching should be introduced, along with the first language, from Class I. Also, due emphasis should be placed on teaching subjects such as Maths and Science, which are usually perceived as difficult, in ways that encourage students to take them up. Most importantly, ICT should be leveraged in a big way by students and teachers to supplement learning, and by administrators to facilitate transparency in the system.

Vocational education and training (VET) is an important element of a nation's education initiative.

PRESCRIPTION

- **A law on the Right to Education is needed to enhance access to quality elementary education**
- **Curriculum and examinations should encourage conceptual understanding of subjects**
- **Vocational education must be made flexible and linked with school and higher education**